



THE SAME CITY NOW BOWS TO THE MIGHT OF GANGSTERS AND CRIMINALS.

from this most populated city of Uttar Pradesh. The city's population—over 1.2 million—grows by 2 per cent every year.

Allahabad is going to pieces, and some are only happy to pick up what they want. Gangsters like Atiq Ahmed, recently found enjoying the luxury of a railway guesthouse when he was supposed to be in judicial custody, have started appropriating parts of the city for themselves. Ahmed alone is believed to have grabbed land worth over Rs 100 crore in the city; the law is simply not strong enough to prevent this activity. City residents say Allahabad had “liberated” itself during the great mutiny of 1857 but the same city now bows to the might of gangsters and criminals. “I would not hesitate in conceding the fact that the old Allahabad city is losing its identity and is being dismantled systematically. The old residents are migrating out of the city and people from villages and towns are moving in,” Neelum Saran Gaur, editor of the recent Marg book *Allahabad: Where*

The Rivers Meet, told INDIA TODAY. She added, “Perhaps migration is changing the face of the city. I cannot say. I am confused whether it is good or bad.”

What troubles the residents the most is the paling of Allahabad's colonial past. The city had never been as culturally powerful as Varanasi for the Hindus or Lucknow for the Muslims or an industrial region like Kanpur, but it had been the seat of power as the capital of a province before Independence and thus of officialdom and state institutions. For the British and the elite among the Indians, the Civil Lines market was the posh haunt of the city, much like Hazratganj in Lucknow and Connaught Place in Delhi. “Civil Lines is no more safe,” says Sumitra Ugra, 65, whose father J.N. Ugra was the commissioner and the district magistrate of Allahabad. “Gone are the days when we as young girls would take an evening stroll here. I doubt if any girl can go alone in the market and return unscathed,” she says.

CHOKED UP

The pitiable state of the area near Clock Tower at Johnston-ganj; (left) vegetable vendors have taken over the entry to Bharati Bhavan Library, set up in 1889 by Pt. Madan Mohan Malviya and Bal Krishna Bhatt